Early the next morning a man going to work thought he heard a groan as he walked along the top of the dike. Looking over the edge, he saw a child clinging to the side of the great wall.

"What's the matter?" he called. "Are you hurt?"

"I'm keeping the water back!" Peter yelled. "Tell them to come quickly!"

The alarm was spread. People came running with shovels and the hole was soon mended.

They carried Peter home to his parents, and before long the whole town knew how he had saved their lives that night. To this day, they have never forgotten the brave little hero of Holland.

About the author



Mary Mapes Dodge (1831–1905) was an American children's author and editor, best known for her novel **Hans Brinker**. She was the recognized leader in juvenile literature for almost a third of the nineteenth century. Dodge conducted **St. Nicholas** for more than thirty years, and it became one of the most successful magazines for children. She was able to persuade many of the great writers of the world to contribute to her children's magazine – *Mark Twain, Louisa May Alcott, Robert Louis Stevenson, Tennyson* etc.

Glossary

dikes (n) - an embankment for controlling or holding back the waters of the sea or a river.

sluices (n) - a sliding gate or other device for controlling the flow of water, especially one in a lock gate.

trickling (v) - flowing in a small stream (a liquid)

numb (adj.) - deprived of the power of sensation.

chattered (v) - feeling cold and frightened that one can't stop the upper teeth from against ones lower teeth.

crouching (v) - adopting a position where the knees are bent and the upper body is brought forward and down.

groan (v) - make a deep inarticulate sound conveying pain

shovels (n) - tool resembling a spade with a broad blade and typically upturned side, used for moving earth, coal, snow etc.

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